

December 05, 2025

Director Debi Durham
Iowa Finance Authority
Iowa Economic Development Authority
1963 Bell Avenue

Dear Ms. Durham,

We are reaching out with this letter because we believe both that knowledge is power and that the Iowa Finance Authority (IFA) website has a wealth of knowledge for Iowa residents. The website has more than 380 links to various articles and webpages, representing a serious undertaking meant to improve the lives of people across Iowa. This is no trivial website and clearly represents an impressive investment of time and manpower.

The average age of American citizens is steadily rising, and Iowa, as in many things, is representative of this new status quo (Mackun). We believe that it is important for website design to be simple so as many people as possible can access the important resources available on the IFA website.

We believe that establishing an alphabetical index of resources, enhancing category clarity and redundancy, and ensuring wording consistency would be simple yet effective changes that would help expand the impact this website can have on Iowa citizens. In the survey we conducted, the data was similar enough among all participants, so further testing is likely not needed at this stage. Further testing could be productive at a later stage if the changes outlined in this report are made.

Thank you for considering our recommendation report. We appreciate you taking time out of your day to review this document and promise we believe it is worth your time. If you have any questions regarding the contents of this report, the survey we conducted, or data we collected from the IFA website, please do not hesitate to reach out with questions.

Respectfully,

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Recommendation Report for the Iowa Finance Authority Website

To Ms. Debi Durham

Sent December 07, 2025

From Isaac Fritz, Naomi Mauss, Osazee Osunde, and Carter Stricker

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Executive Summary

This report presents the findings of a usability and accessibility study of the Iowa Finance Authority (IFA) website, assessing its effectiveness, efficiency and clarity for Iowa residents. The study involved 20 Iowans who were asked to complete four specific, real-world scenarios on the website. The core finding is that despite the IFA website containing a wealth of valuable resources, its current structure and design pose significant usability and accessibility challenges that hinder efficient information retrieval.

The primary difficulty identified was the users' struggle to navigate the site without heavy reliance on the search function. This struggle stems from several key issues namely, unclear categorization within the main tabs, inconsistent or non-matching terminology between main headers and internal page titles, and a lack of immediate visibility for external links and resources.

Based on the results from the study, to enhance the usability of the website, an effective renovation of the website would:

1. **Establish an Alphabetical Index of Resources:** Creating a comprehensive, alphabetized index of all available resources will provide an alternative, more reliable method for users—especially those struggling with the search bar or category logic—to locate specific webpages, regardless of the exact wording.
2. **Enhance Category Clarity and Redundancy:** The main 'tabs' on the homepage require serious consideration to ensure their titles clearly reflect their contents. More importantly, information that logically fits under multiple categories should have duplicate links placed under each relevant tab to improve discoverability and reduce navigational errors.
3. **Ensure Wording Consistency:** Titles on the main navigation tabs must consistently match the headings and subcategories on the corresponding internal pages. The existing discrepancy in terminology significantly complicates navigation, forcing over-reliance on the search function.

Implementing these changes—focusing on broader categories, making a clear way for ordinary citizens to navigate the website, and checking for internal consistency for important vocabulary—will improve the website's clarity and expand its positive impact by making essential resources more readily accessible to a wider, and increasingly aging, demographic of Iowa residents.

Introduction

Purpose

The purpose of this report is to evaluate the usability and accessibility of the Iowa Finance Authority (IFA) website and recommend changes that may improve its overall efficiency and clarity for Iowa residents. The report examines the challenges users encounter when navigating the site and summarizes the findings of a usability study conducted with Iowan participants. The study was conducted because multiple people independently voiced concerns that the website was difficult to navigate. The survey was a means of determining whether this was an opinion held by just a few people or a general trend which needs to be remedied.

Scope

This report focuses on the usability of the IFA website as experienced by a sample of Iowa residents. Participants were asked to complete a series of tasks designed to test the website's organization and search functionality. The scope of this study is limited to English-speaking users operating modern Windows operating systems. This report evaluates user navigation, overall user experience, and clarity of the interface design. It does not address mobile usability, or multilingual accessibility.

Assumptions

This study assumes that participants accurately reported their prior experience with the IFA website and that their feedback reflects their genuine perceptions of usability. It assumes that the testing environments used during the study mostly represented the environments in which most Iowa residents access the website. Finally, the study assumes that all participants possessed at least a basic understanding of standard web navigation.

Methods

Subject Selection

This study consisted entirely of Iowa citizens, with some attempt made to select from a diverse pool of ages, genders, and academic backgrounds. However, the limited scope means that the subjects were not totally randomly selected from the population, and a convenience sample was used. This project selected 20 subjects because 12-13 people is considered optimal for a qualitative report (Wynter), but wanted a larger sample size was chosen to avoid bias caused by different levels of technical skill. It has also been found that 15 people will identify up to 99% of usability issues, meaning that the sample used here should bring as much beneficial feedback as reasonably possible.

Study Environment

We conducted the study by asking participants to follow a set procedure written out as a protocol all proctors followed. There were varied testing environments, under the assumption that the different participants should represent the different kinds of people who use the website. However, the testing environment was generally in an area with limited sound and with faster internet speeds.

Secondary Research

We conducted online research to find a general consensus on the standards for conducting a usability study. This was both to inform the process in ensuring that it meets the minimum statistical requirements and to ensure it meets professional standards.

Limitations

This usability study was limited in its ability to test the linguistic and visual capacity of the website. It is likely the website would be significantly more difficult to navigate if the person attempting to navigate it were blind or had a limited understanding of English. Additionally, this project is focused on people from Iowa; everyone surveyed was from Iowa. Therefore, this project is biased in that it only considers the needs of people already living in Iowa. All participants used Windows 11 or Windows 10, so any users on lower-level operating systems may find issues not covered in this usability study.

Definitions

Subcategory is a drop-down menu which provides more specific options within a primary navigation category.

Criteria

Various target data was established before running the study, such that certain diagnostic criteria could be analyzed. In order to achieve the information desired, specific tasks that someone could plausibly encounter in a real-world scenario were designed, and in some cases a time limit was established. Each participant was given the same four scenarios in the same order to attempt.

1. Success/Failure

Of the collected data, the most important is that which shows how successful people were in finding data on the IFA website. It was noted whether the given participant successfully completed the task, failed to find the correct page and information in a specified amount of time, or if they gave up at any point. A success for each scenario was considered as the participant reaching the correct page of the website, with the ability to recite or present the requested data.

2. Efficiency

Another primary thing being surveyed was how long each task took for a participant. In order to evaluate this, a record was taken of how many times the subject clicked any link on website, the amount they attempted a search query, and number of times they returned to the homepage for a fresh start for each scenario.

3. Method of Completion

We also found it important to observe the direction subjects took in order to complete each assigned task. To achieve this, it was noted whether participants were mainly clicking links in their attempt to complete their goal, or if they used the search function. This would be helpful in knowing which desired method was more effective in completing the tasks.

4. Satisfaction vs Expectation

Lastly, the survey attempted to determine the overall experience each participant had. Users were asked for their thoughts on the following to get an impression of where each participant thought the website could use improvement based on their experience and usual habits:

1. Was the search function located where you expected it?
2. Were you able to find information you needed using the search function?
3. Were you able to find information you needed without using the search function?
4. Were you able to easily return to the home page to start the next scenario once you found what you needed?
5. Did you find the information you were assigned?
6. When you use a site similar to this (or this site) do you typically use the search function, or do you follow links to get where you want?
7. How satisfied were you with your experience using this website?

5. Background Information

At the start of each survey, participants were asked for their age, gender, profession or college major, their estimated hours per week on the internet, and if they had ever used the IFA website before. The goal was to identify any influence or correlation in the data at the end that may be useful. The background information was largely homogenous for all relevant statistics, so this is not referenced later in the document.

The candidates were then presented with four hypothetical scenarios, each of which had an associated 'goal.' The tasks are as listed below.

Scenarios

Task 1: Create a Dashboard to analyze economic conditions of a city in Iowa.

You're interested in how well a city's housing market is compared to all of Iowa. You want to view the statistics for the city's housing market to have quantitative data to support your decisions. Can you use this website to generate a report on Ames' housing market compared to Des Moines' housing market? You will have five minutes maximum; nothing is necessarily wrong if you are unable to navigate to the webpage in that time. If at any point you are inclined to give up, that is an option.

Task 2: Identify past grant recipients and determine how to apply for a grant

You are an artist looking to get funding for a new street art project within the city of Ames you want to see who previously got funding and then you want to apply for funding of your own. Can you navigate to the correct section in order to apply?

Task 3: Generate data that will compare living conditions in Iowa versus Minnesota

You just finished high-school and are deciding between two colleges located in two different states, Iowa and Minnesota. You want to generate a comparison of the two states that displays both the percentage of the population that has a bachelor's degree, and the average rent you might expect to pay at each location.

Task 4: Determine the minimum necessary credit score for application to a program

You are a college senior planning to graduate in six months and are looking to purchase your first home in Iowa shortly after you start your full-time job. You want to see if you qualify for the IFA's FirstHome Program. Find the FirstHome Program page and use the website's tool or guide to quickly check the minimum credit score requirement for the program.

Results

After administrating the survey to all participants, both quantitative and qualitative information were gathered from to gauge their takeaways from the experience. The findings below correspond to their respective numbered criterion.

1. Success/Failure

Throughout every task presented, there was an average success rate of 58.75%. This comes from scenario one with a success rate of 50%, scenario two with a success rate of 80%, scenario three with 5%, and lastly scenario four with a 100% success rate. On top of that, before the participants were given guidance to search in scenario one, this task only had a 50% success rate, and without any help at all, it had a complete failure at a 0% success rate. As a result, the average success rate between all scenarios with no guidance was 46.25%. This low completion percentage also suffers due to many testers choosing to give up after struggling to find their way to the correct page.

2. Efficiency

The efficiency of the website was assessed by how long each given task took. Additionally, this criterion includes how many times users had to click a link in order to find what they were looking for, compared to the number of clicks it actually takes to reach the correct page. Returning to the home page to restart inflates these numbers but also highlights how frequently an incorrect page was visited.

The average number of clicks it took to reach the correct page was five clicks when considering successful trails. Unsuccessful trials were excluded from this statistic because it is unknown how many more links it would take the participant before they found the solution. Many participants were unable to complete the specified goal after any number of clicks, adding to the inefficiency of the current layout.

3. Method of Completion

To determine the method of completion, the participant was asked both how they typically navigate websites, as well as what they ended up opting for based on link clicks and search queries. The survey found that for two of the four scenarios which required less clicks, the links were highly favored, but on the other two there were an average of 6 clicks, rarely leading participants to the page they were looking for.

4. Satisfaction vs Expectation

The overall user experience concluded with most participants only being able to succeed at half of the scenarios. The figure below displays the data of what each participant rated their experience with the website on a range from zero to ten.

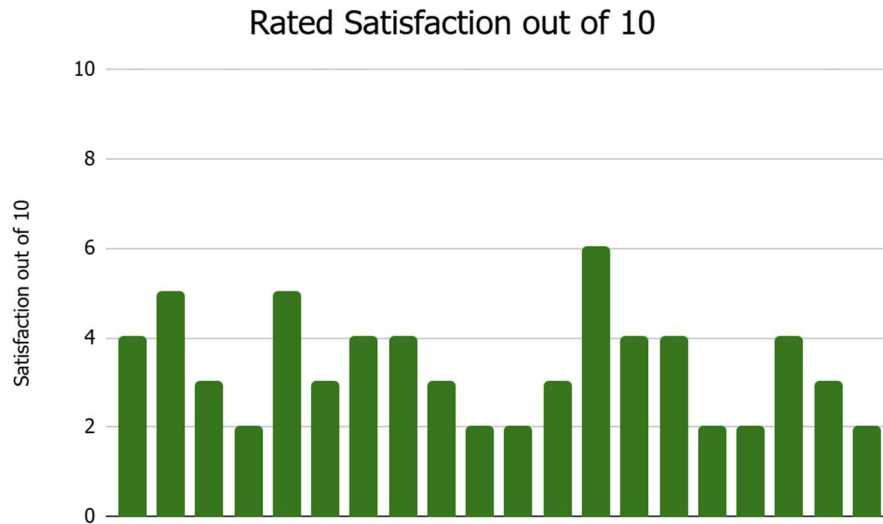


Fig. 1: Overall Website Satisfaction

5. Background Information

We found before starting the survey that every participant was new to the website. The average number of hours they spent on the internet each week may have led to improved success and efficiency at each scenario.

One notable potential growth area is in the ease with which people were able to find and generate data. In the first scenario, no subject was able to navigate to the Iowa profile dashboard without the use of a search tool, and only half were able to locate the dashboard after being given a prompt in which they are explicitly given the term 'dashboard.' The inability of most survey participants to locate data when given the relevant search term speaks to a system which is difficult to navigate.

Later, task three asked subjects to generate data which would compare basic facts about living in Iowa versus living in Minnesota. This could be important in determining whether new residents decide to settle in Iowa over Minnesota. Despite the potential importance of this data, only a strikingly small minority of people were able to find the relevant data.

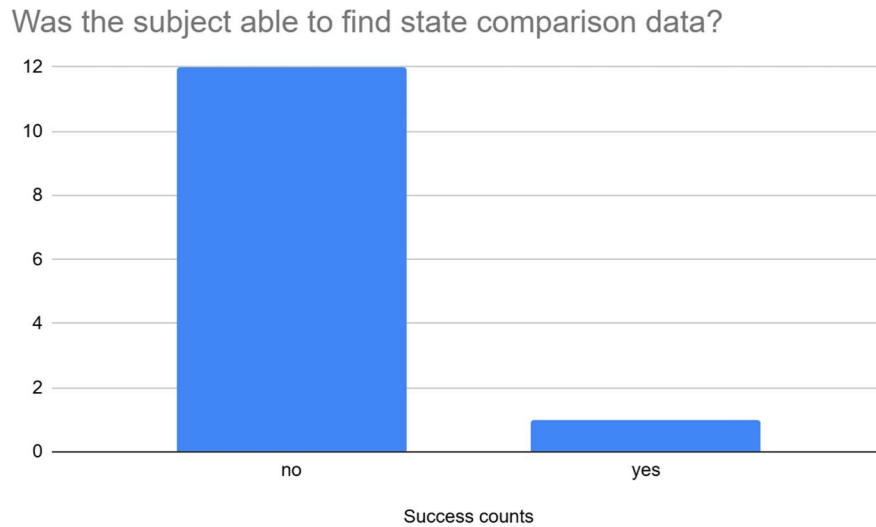


Fig. 2: Success Rate for Comparison Data

While it is certainly important and influential to know where subjects failed to complete a task, information regarding how they might have preferred to complete a task may give insights into why they failed to complete a task. The most obvious place to start is whether their use of the search bar increased the rate at which subjects were able to locate information across the website.

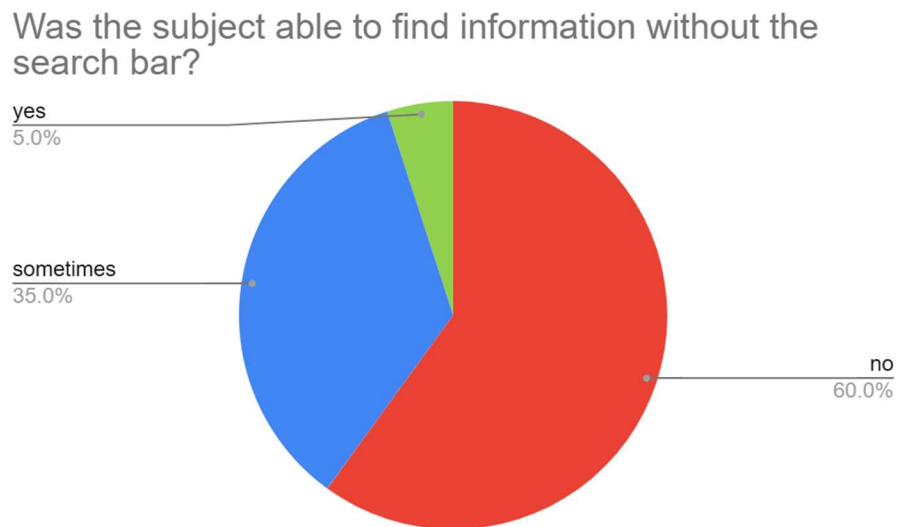


Fig. 3: Rate of Information Retrieval Without Using the Search Bar

As seen in Image 3, almost 2 of 3 people given the usability survey were able to find information with the search bar. Of the remainder, only one person felt confident in their ability to find information on the IFA website without the search bar.

The search bar is not, of course, the only way to find information on the website. Subjects were then asked whether they were able to find information on the website with the use of the search bar, as is represented below in Image 4.

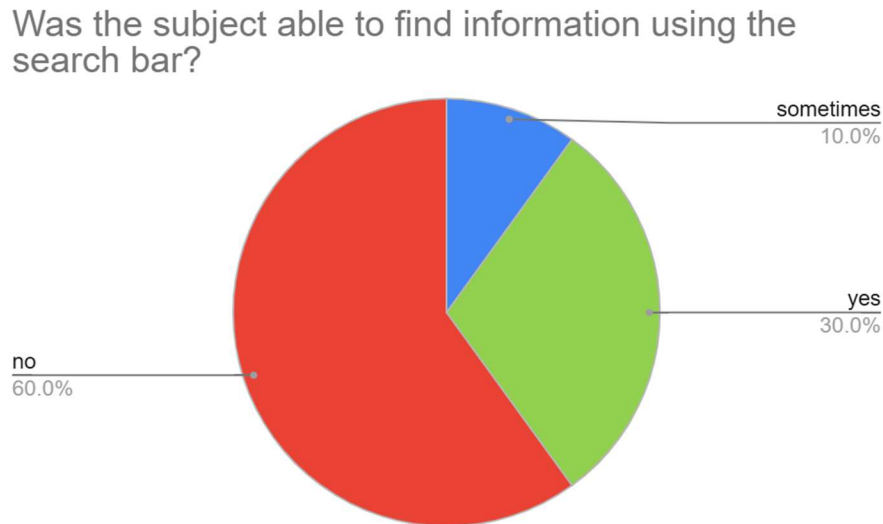


Fig. 4: Rate of Information Retrieval Using the Search Bar

We can see above that a majority of people still felt that they were unable to find data on the IFA website with the use of the search bar. Here, what is now thirty percent of people feel that they were able to find information with the search tool. If the study assumes that the people who were able to find information with the search bar and people able to find information using links are totally independent and unique people, this still leaves over half of the sample population either unconfident or unable to find information throughout the website.

Generally, this project operated under the belief that if the majority of people sampled are unable to navigate to a given website, then attempts at improving navigability should be taken immediately.

Once it has been established that a greater ease in finding information is important, the next question is how navigability can be improved. It only does so much to improve a functionality nobody uses. So, to ensure no steps were called for that wouldn't be used, people were asked whether they preferred to use the search bar or links on a webpage were their typical method of navigating a website.

Preference Between Searching and Using Links

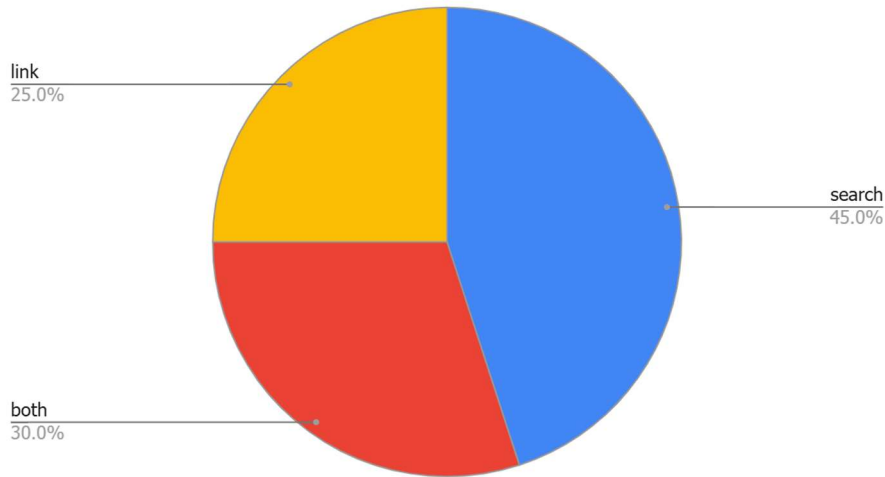


Fig. 5: Preference Between the Search Bar and Links

Search is used as a primary form of locating information, followed by those who prefer to use links and the search function, and those who use solely links being the least popular. Based on the above, it would be most effective to improve the search function on the IFA website and to then expand the efficacy of links to direct people to the necessary webpage.

Conclusions and Recommendations

The results of this usability study indicate that users experience notable difficulty navigating the Iowa Finance Authority (IFA) website, particularly when attempting to locate information without relying on the search function. Participants struggled most with unclear categorization, inconsistent wording between tabs and subpages, and difficulty keeping track of which subcategory they had already viewed. While some tasks were successfully completed, participants required a fair amount of time, made multiple navigation errors, and expressed not knowing where key information could be located. These findings suggest that the current structure of the website does not adequately support efficient information navigation and retrieval.

It will be important to improve the website's ability to be navigable, as most participants expressed low confidence in their ability to find information using the site's navigation or the search function. The participants heavy use of the search also exposed some flaws in the current keyword-tagging system, which prevented users from finding relevant content even when using the correct terms. High numbers of links within categories further added to user frustration and led to the abandonment of some tasks before completion, demonstrating a need for clearer organization.

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are proposed:

1. **Establish an Alphabetical Index of Resources:** Creating a comprehensive, alphabetized index of all available resources will provide an alternative, more reliable method for users—especially those struggling with the search bar or category logic—to locate specific webpages, regardless of the exact wording.

2. **Enhance Category Clarity and Redundancy:** The main 'tabs' on the homepage require serious consideration to ensure their titles clearly reflect their contents. More importantly, information that logically fits under multiple categories should have duplicate links placed under each relevant tab to improve discoverability and reduce navigational errors.
3. **Ensure Wording Consistency:** Titles on the main navigation tabs must consistently match the headings and subcategories on the corresponding internal pages. The existing discrepancy in terminology significantly complicates navigation, forcing over-reliance on the search function.

Overall, the data gathered from this sample of Iowa residents demonstrates that improvements to the organization, labeling, and clarity would greatly increase the accessibility and effectiveness of the IFA website.

Bibliography

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Appendix

The site tested was the Iowa Finance Authority, which can be accessed by following the link attached below:

<https://opportunityiowa.gov/>